MSc Creative Computing

Practice as Research — Lecture 2
How practice produces knowledge

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Lecture 2 of 8 — How practice produces knowledge

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Recap: where we left off

Last week we established:

1. Research is a structured attempt to produce something not previously known, in a form others can examine.
2. Practice-based research mostly produces **procedural, tacit, and situated** knowledge.
3. The difference between a project and a research project is naming the **edge**, the **wager**, and the **test**.

Today's question: *how* does practice do this? What are the mechanisms? And who has tried to map them?

Three texts, three frames

We're working with three attempts to explain how practice produces knowledge:

- **Smith & Dean (2009)** — practice and research as an *iterative cycle*, not two separate activities.
- **Candy (2006)** — a distinction between *practice-based* and *practice-led* research, and what counts as evidence.
- **Borgdorff (2011)** — a philosophical argument that artistic practice is *itself* a form of knowledge production, not merely the subject of it.

Each gives you a different angle. None is complete alone.

Why does this matter practically?

Because at some point you'll need to answer these questions about your own work:

- What kind of knowledge is my project producing?
- How do I know it's new?
- How do I show someone else it's real?
- Where does the knowledge *live* — in the artefact, in the documentation, in the method, or somewhere else?

If you can't answer these, you have a project but not yet a research project.

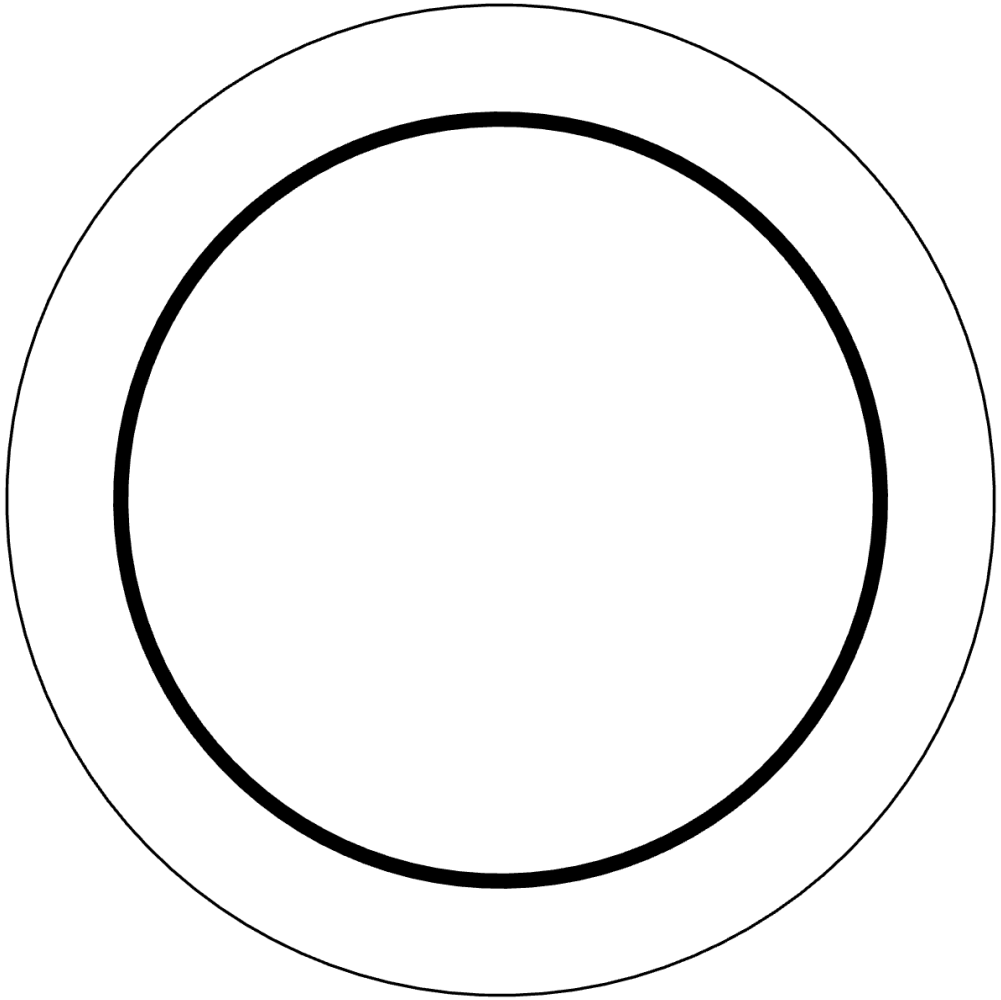
Smith & Dean: the iterative cyclic web

Smith & Dean's central contribution is a diagram — the "iterative cyclic web of practice-led research and research-led practice."

The key insight: **practice and research are not sequential** (first I research, then I make — or first I make, then I write about it). They are interleaved and mutually generative.

- Practice generates questions that research cannot anticipate.
- Research reframes what you're doing in the studio, and opens directions you wouldn't have found by making alone.

The cycle runs continuously, not once.



Smith & Dean: unpacking the cycle

The diagram has **three nodes**, not a linear sequence:

1. **Practice / creative work**
2. **Research**
3. **Output** (artefact and/or text)

Two paths run through these nodes simultaneously:

- **Clockwise: the creative practice path.** Practice generates output, output prompts further practice.
- **Anticlockwise: the research path.** Research reframes the output, the output raises new research questions.

The two paths intersect and feed each other at every node. That's what makes it a *web*, not a pipeline. At any point, the direction of travel can reverse — a research insight redirects the practice, a surprise in the studio sends you back to the literature.

Research
Idea generation
Creative practice
Selection of empirical approach (subjective or systematic)
Investigate data, ideas, and/or relevant theory
Idea selection (subjective or systematic)
Investigate and extrapolate from the ideas
Practice-led research
Academic research
Output: documentation of the artwork and Its production
Output: methods, results, ideas, critical accounts, theorisations as research publications
Develop, interpret and synthesise new data or ideas
Dev elop chosen ideas
Output: artwork
Research-led practice
Test the theory empirically or refine the theory/idea through comparison and argument
Theorise ideas and dev elop techniques as method
Output: new technique,theory or paradigm
Output: theories and techniques
Application of theories and techniques to new creative work

Smith & Dean: what this means for you

Practically, the iterative cyclic web tells you:

- **Don't wait to finish making before you start contextualising.** Read while you make. Let the reading change what you make. Let the making change what you read.
- **Don't treat the written output as a retrospective report.** It's a living document that evolves alongside the practice.
- **Expect your research question to change.** If it doesn't, you probably aren't genuinely cycling.

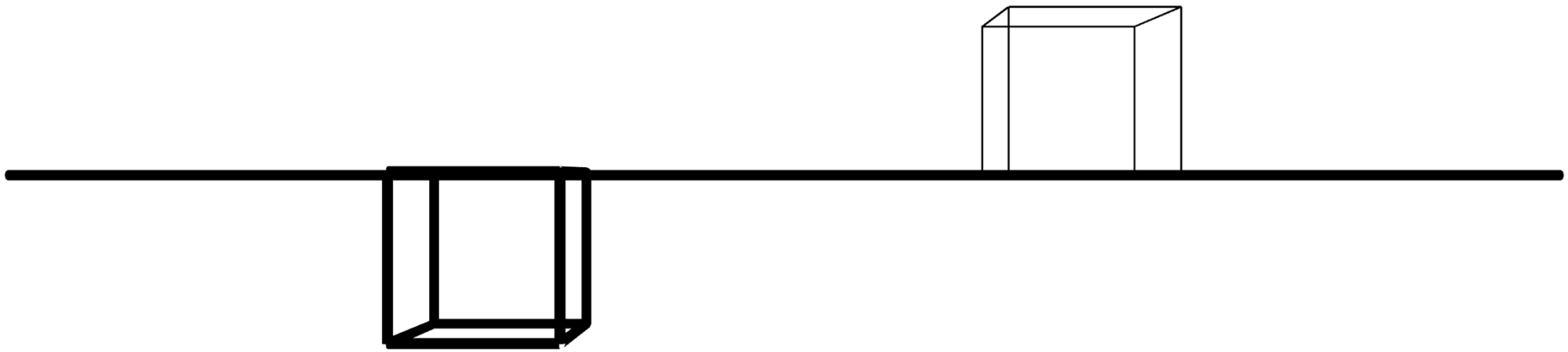
This is why I asked you to read, make, and refine *every week*.

Candy: practice-based vs practice-led

Linda Candy draws a distinction that the field now uses routinely:

Practice-based research: the creative artefact is the *basis* of the contribution to knowledge. The claim cannot be made without the artefact. The artefact is not an illustration of the research — it *is* the research, or at least an indispensable part of it.

Practice-led research: practice is the *method* that leads to new understandings, but the contribution is primarily articulated in a text — a paper, a thesis, a framework. The practice informs the research but the knowledge output is separable from the artefact.



Candy: why the distinction matters

The distinction is not about quality — it's about **where the knowledge lives** and **how you demonstrate it**.

If your work is **practice-based:**

- The artefact must be accessible (exhibited, documented, demonstrated).
- You must still articulate *what* knowledge the artefact embodies — but the artefact does crucial work that the writing alone cannot.
- Your examiner, reviewer, or audience needs to *experience* the work, not just read about it.

If your work is **practice-led:**

- The written output carries the primary claim.
- The practice generates insight, but the insight is transferable beyond that specific work.
- The artefact supports the argument but doesn't *replace* it.

Most MSc projects at CCI are practice-based. Know which one yours is, and why.

Candy: what counts as evidence?

Candy is practical about this. Evidence in practice-based research can include:

- The artefact itself, presented in a context where it can be encountered.
- Documentation of process (notebooks, iterations, code repositories, video).
- Reflective commentary that connects the decisions made to the knowledge produced.
- Peer response — exhibition feedback, review, critical reception.
- Comparative analysis — how the work differs from, extends, or challenges existing work.

None of these alone is sufficient. The strength is in their combination.

Borgdorff: the production of knowledge in artistic research

Henk Borgdorff makes a stronger philosophical claim than either Smith & Dean or Candy.

He argues that **artistic practice is not merely a vehicle for research** — it is a *mode of knowledge production* in its own right. The practice doesn't just inform the research; the practice *is* research.

To make this argument, he draws on a three-part distinction (originally from Christopher Frayling, 1993):

- Research **into** the arts — studying art from the outside (art history, aesthetics, sociology of art).
- Research **for** the arts — instrumental research that serves practice (materials science, tool development).
- Research **through** the arts — research where the artistic practice itself is the epistemic activity.

Borgdorff's position is that the third category — research *through* the arts — is epistemologically legitimate and distinct.

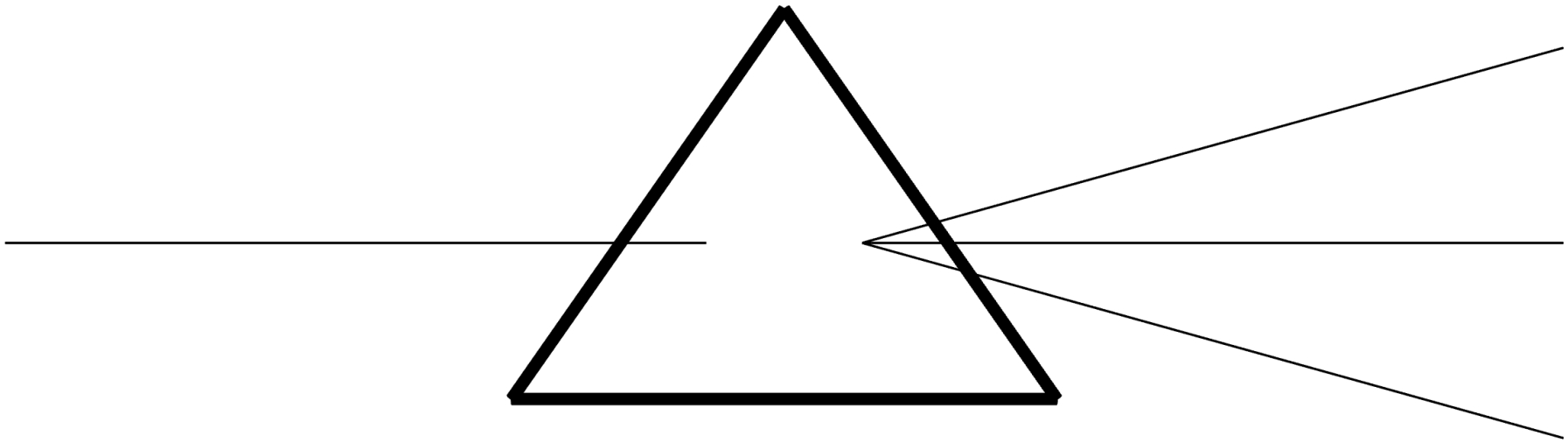
Borgdorff: what makes it "research"?

Borgdorff anticipates the obvious objection: "If making art is research, isn't *all* art research?"

His answer: no. Artistic practice becomes research when it satisfies three conditions:

1. **Intent** — the practitioner sets out to produce knowledge, not only to make a work.
2. **Method** — the practice follows some discernible method, even if emergent or improvised, that can be articulated and examined.
3. **Context** — the work is situated within a relevant discourse, contributing to an ongoing conversation in a field.

Without intent, you have craft. Without method, you have intuition. Without context, you have self-expression. All three have value — but none alone is research.



Borgdorff: knowledge that doesn't fit neatly into words

Borgdorff makes a further suggestion that matters for your work. He argues that the knowledge produced through artistic research is often:

- **Non-propositional** — it can't be fully captured in statements of the form "X is true."
- **Embodied** — it's carried in materials, processes, physical actions, perceptual experiences.
- **Non-discursive** — it communicates through forms other than language (sound, movement, visual structure, interaction).

This doesn't make it less real or less rigorous. It means the methods of demonstrating it are different from writing a paper. The artefact, the performance, the installation — these are the *vehicles* of the knowledge, not just examples of it.

Putting the three together

	Smith & Dean	Candy	Borgdorff
Central claim	Practice and research form an iterative cycle	Practice-based and practice-led are distinct modes	Artistic practice is itself a form of knowledge production
Where knowledge lives	Distributed across the cycle — artefact, text, process	Depends on mode — artefact (based) or text (led)	In the practice and its material outputs
Strength	Maps the *process* clearly	Gives you practical categories for structuring a project	Provides the philosophical justification
Limitation	Descriptive — doesn't tell you how to evaluate quality	The binary can oversimplify hybrid projects	Can be used to excuse weak articulation ("the work speaks for itself")

The trap: "the work speaks for itself"

The most common misuse of these frameworks — especially Borgdorff's — is the claim that artistic research doesn't need to be articulated because **the work speaks for itself.**

It doesn't. Or rather: it does, but not to everyone, and not about everything.

- The artefact communicates *something*. But it doesn't communicate its own context, its relationship to prior work, or why its contribution matters.
- You still need to write. The writing doesn't replace the work — it does the things the work *can't* do.
- Borgdorff himself is explicit: non-discursive knowledge still needs a discursive frame. The two are complementary.

Don't use these texts as a reason not to write. Use them as a reason to write *differently*.

What this means for your project

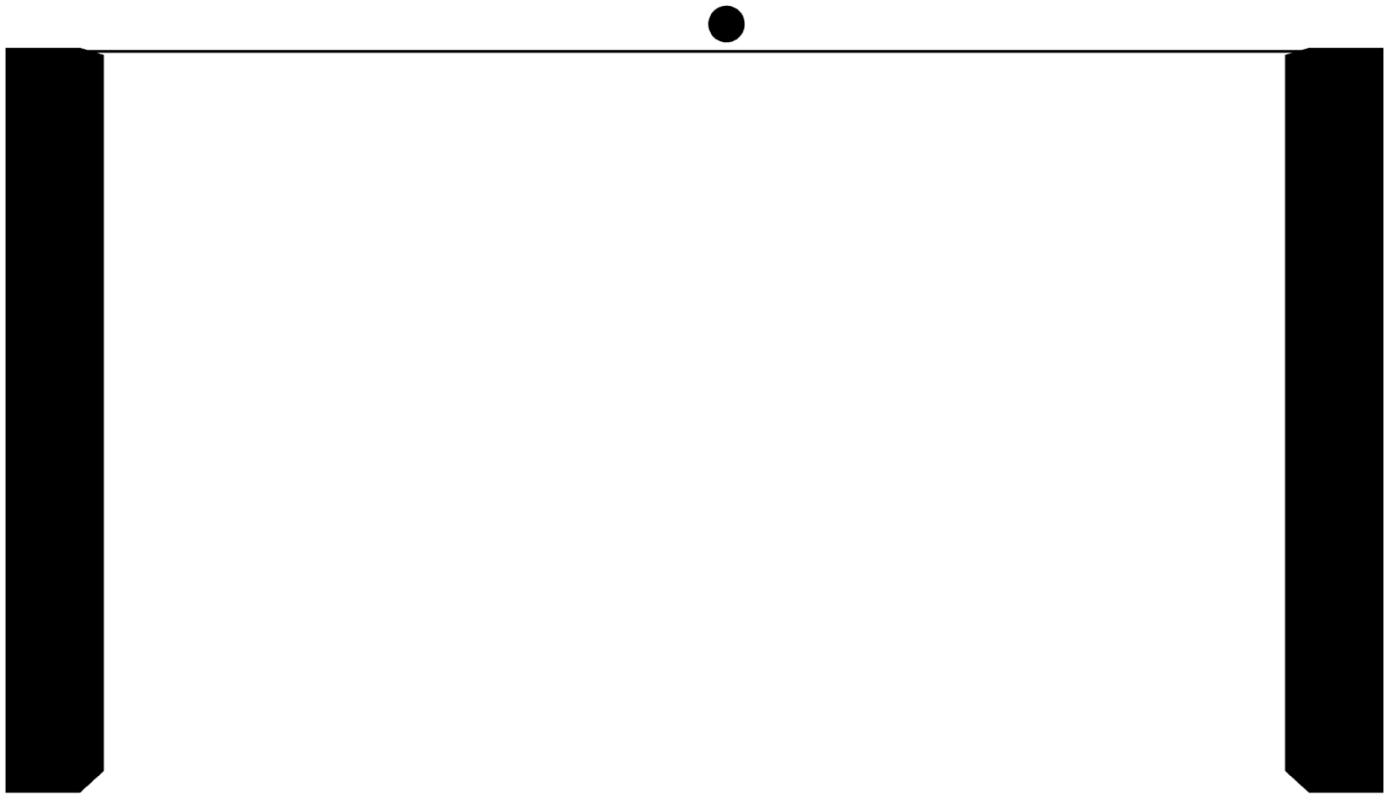
Some direct implications:

Your process is part of your output. Document it from the start. Not for assessment bureaucracy — because the choices you make *are* the research.

Your reading and your making should talk to each other. If your reading list never changes what you build, you're not cycling. If your making never changes what you read, same problem.

Know which mode you're in. Are you producing knowledge that lives *in* the artefact (practice-based) or knowledge that the artefact helped you discover but that can be stated independently (practice-led)? This determines how you structure everything from documentation to final submission.

Articulate, articulate, articulate. The frameworks give you permission to let the artefact do real epistemic work — but they don't give you permission to be vague about what that work is.



Discussion / exercise (15 minutes)

In pairs or small groups:

1. Take your current project idea (or a project you admire).
2. Try to describe it in Candy's terms: is it **practice-based** or **practice-led**?
3. Then apply Borgdorff's three conditions: does it have **intent**, **method**, and **context**?
4. Finally, where are you in Smith & Dean's cycle right now? Which zone are you spending most time in? Which are you neglecting?

Be honest. The point is diagnosis, not performance.

For next week

Week 3: **Situating research in a field — finding the GAP.**

Read **one** of:

- A published paper in your area of interest — any venue (NeurIPS, ISEA, Leonardo, SIGGRAPH, CHI, NIME, etc.)
- A review or survey paper that maps a field relevant to your project.

Write a **half-page note** answering:

- What does this paper *claim* is new?
- What prior work does it cite?
- What does it *not* address — and could that gap be your gap?

Bring the note and the paper reference to the session.

Key takeaways

1. **Practice and research are not sequential — they cycle.** (Smith & Dean)
2. **Know whether your knowledge lives in the artefact or in the text — and build accordingly.** (Candy)
3. **Artistic practice can be a legitimate mode of inquiry — but only with intent, method, and context.** (Borgdorff)
4. **"The work speaks for itself" is almost always wrong.** Write differently, not less.
5. **Your process is your research.** Document it now. Not later. Now.

Questions

What's unclear?
What do you disagree with?
What does this change about how you're thinking about your project?